

TEOTIHUACÁN—THE METROPOLIS

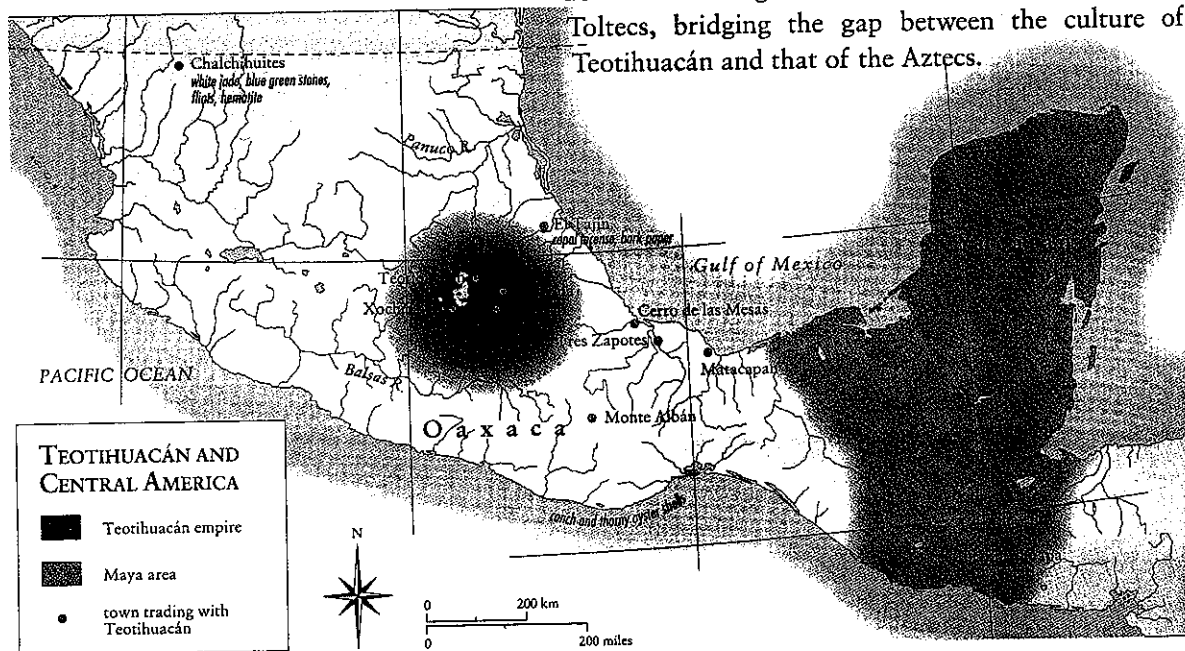
Mesoamerica was dominated by the power of the city of Teotihuacán for several hundred years. It was located 28 miles away from modern Mexico City.

Teotihuacán grew dramatically during the first few centuries after Christ, reaching a peak population well over 100,000 and perhaps in excess of 200,000 by the middle of the Classic period. This made it not only the largest city in the Americas, but among the half-dozen largest cities in the world at the time.

Around AD 200 more than 80 percent of the population of the Basin of Mexico lived in Teotihuacán. This concentration of regional population in Teotihuacán, together with the rigidity of its plan, has suggested the exercise of absolute political control to many scholars. It is likely that because the city enjoyed such an important place in religion, and because it was a very important economic center, it was attractive for people to live there.

Religious architecture dominated the city. The most imposing buildings were laid out along the so-called Avenue of the Dead. These included the largest pyramids to be seen in Mesoamerica, known as the Pyramid of the Sun and the Pyramid of the Moon. The latter guards the northern end of the central axis, the Avenue of the Dead. The Pyramid of the Sun is located east of the Avenue, and it faces west. The original buildings were built with the typical style of *talud* (talus) and *tablero* (entablature), or panel-and-slope wall profiles. At Teotihuacán the *tablero* always was larger than the *talud*. This style of architecture was introduced in about AD 200, and became almost ubiquitous during the next 500 years on the stepped pyramids that are typical of the city's religious architecture. This type of architecture can also be seen at the Great Temple of the Aztecs, the mecca of the Aztecs.

Teotihuacán spread its influence all over Mesoamerica but the site was abandoned and ravaged about AD 650. Next came the Toltecs, bridging the gap between the culture of Teotihuacán and that of the Aztecs.



as dominated by the power of the city of Teotihuacán for several centuries. It was located 28 miles away from modern Mexico City, grew dramatically during the first few centuries after Christ, and reached a population well over 100,000 and perhaps in excess of 200,000 by the Classic period. This made it not only the largest city in the world at the time, but also one of the half-dozen largest cities in the world at the time. More than 80 percent of the population of the Basin of Mexico lived in Teotihuacán. This concentration of regional population in one city, together with the rigidity of its plan, has suggested the exercise of central control to many scholars. It is likely that because the city was so important a place in religion, and because it was a very important center, it was attractive for people to live there.

The city's architecture dominated the city. The most imposing buildings were the so-called Avenue of the Dead. These included the largest pyramid in Mesoamerica, known as the Pyramid of the Sun and the Pyramid of the Moon. The latter guards the northern end of the central axis, the Avenue of the Dead. The Pyramid of the Sun is located east of the Avenue of the Dead. The original buildings were built with the typical style of the Teotihuacán, or panel-and-slope wall profiles. At the time of its construction, this style of architecture was larger than the *talud*. This style of architecture was produced in about AD 200, and became almost ubiquitous during the Classic period. The stepped pyramids that are typical of the city's religious architecture can also be seen at the Great Temple of the Aztecs.

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